

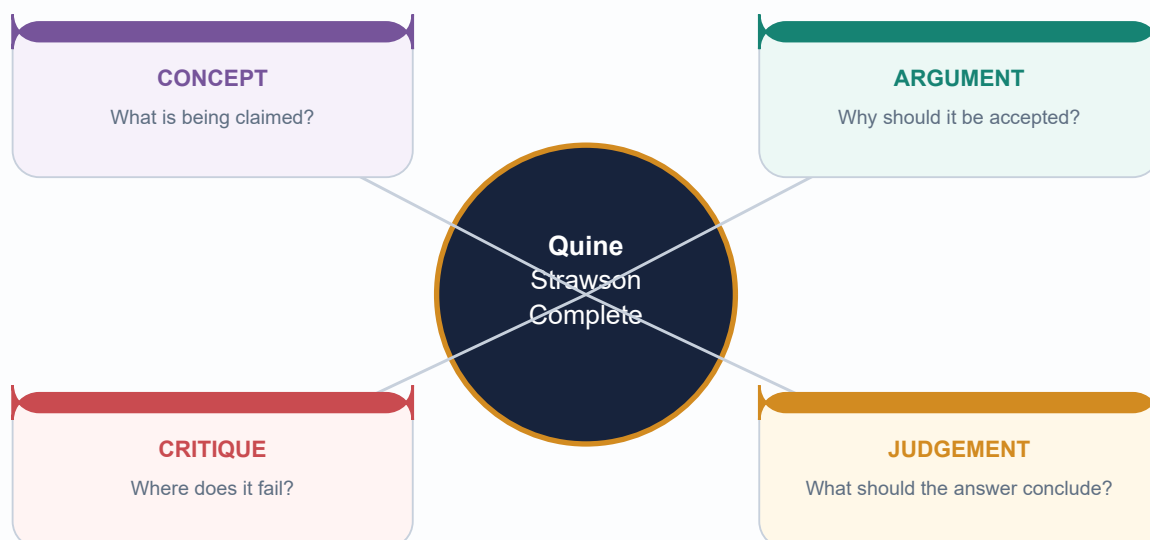
UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Quine and Strawson — Complete Visual Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Syllabus: Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons.

Direct local-book analysis • Verified knowledge cross-check • PYQ-mapped answer writing



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Map, Context and Technical Vocabulary

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Quine reforms empiricism through holism and naturalism, while Strawson revives descriptive metaphysics by identifying material bodies and persons as basic to our conceptual scheme.

Direct local reading: Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 51–86; Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 801–803 (Quine) and 914–916 (Strawson); cross-checked with the local substance and a priori theme files.

TIMELINE

1950 — Strawson criticises Russell on referring

1951 — Quine publishes Two Dogmas of Empiricism

1959 — Strawson's Individuals develops descriptive metaphysics

1960 — Quine's Word and Object extends naturalism and translation indeterminacy

WHOLE-TOPIC DOCTRINE MAP

QUINE AND STRAWSON

Two dogmas Analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism	Holism The web of belief faces experience corporately
Basic particulars Material bodies anchor identification	Persons One primitive subject bears physical and mental predicates

KEY DATA

Term	Precise Meaning	Answer Use
Analyticity	Purported truth by meaning alone	Reconstruct Quine's circularity charge
Reductionism	Each sentence tied to its own confirming experiences	State second dogma
Confirmation holism	Experience tests a system, not isolated statements	Explain revision choice
Basic particular	Re-identifiable object presupposed by reference	Material-body argument
P-/M-predicate	Personal mental / material predicate	Explain person as primitive

STATIC THEORY

- **Syllabus coverage:** Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons.
- **Intellectual context:** Quine reforms empiricism through holism and naturalism, while Strawson revives descriptive metaphysics by identifying material bodies and persons as basic to our conceptual scheme.
- **Source discipline:** claims were reconciled with the verified topic note, recent PYQs and the directly read local books listed below.
- **Theme cross-check:** substance, a priori knowledge and critiques of metaphysics were checked where relevant.

MEMORY HOOK

Quine removes TWO dogmas; Strawson restores TWO basics: material bodies and persons.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Define each technical term before evaluating it.
2. Reconstruct the internal argument, not merely the conclusion.
3. Distinguish the thinker's own doctrine from a later label or criticism.
4. Use comparisons only after identifying the shared philosophical problem.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Quine rejects experience.
CORRECT: He rejects atomistic verification and sharp analyticity, not empiricism itself.
WRONG: Any belief can be retained at no cost.
CORRECT: Retention requires compensating revisions elsewhere in the web.
WRONG: Strawson adds mind and body as two parts.
CORRECT: Person is a primitive single subject, not a composite analysis.

CROSS-SYLLABUS CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Analyticity	Logical positivism	Quine attacks a central distinction
Synthetic a priori	Kant	Holism blurs the a priori/a posteriori boundary
Substance	Aristotle to Hume	Basic particulars reinterpret the bearer question
Person	Descartes and Buddhism	Compare dualist subject, primitive person and no-self

MAINS ANGLE

Open with the problem that generates the doctrine; end by judging its explanatory gain against its strongest internal cost.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 51–86; Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 801–803 (Quine) and 914–916 (Strawson); cross-checked with the local substance and a priori theme files.

HIGH

1. QUINE — CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM ("Two Dogmas") — Part 1

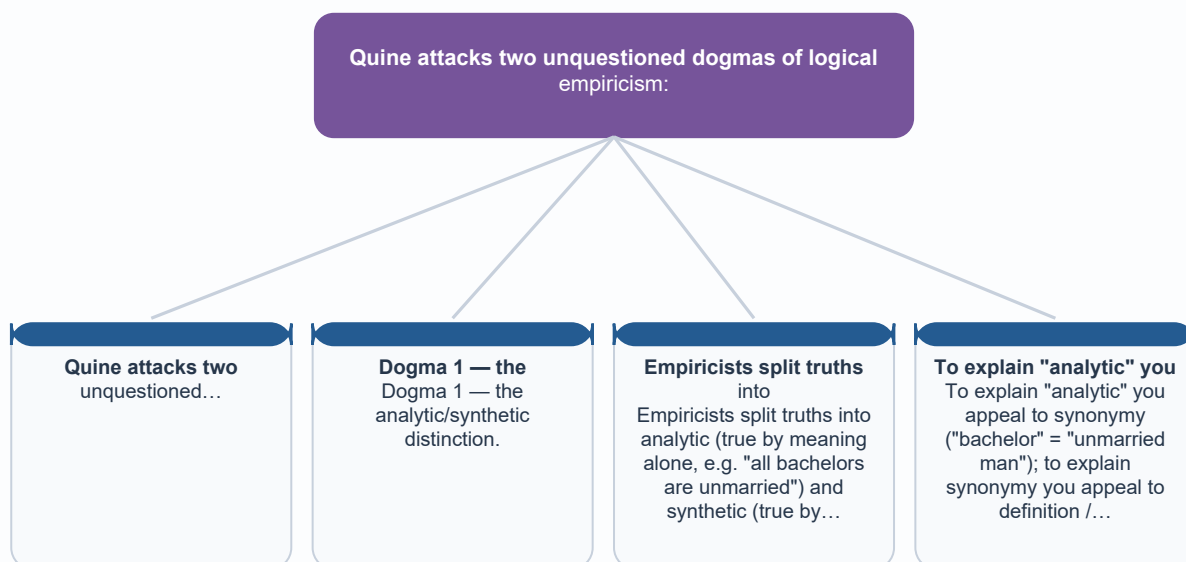
Paper I Western Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Quine attacks two unquestioned dogmas of logical empiricism:

Direct local reading: Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 51–86; Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 801–803 (Quine) and 914–916 (Strawson); cross-checked with the local substance and a priori theme files.

1. QUINE — CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM ("TWO DOGMAS") — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- Quine attacks two unquestioned dogmas of logical empiricism:
- Dogma 1 — the analytic/synthetic distinction.
- Empiricists split truths into analytic (true by meaning alone, e.g. "all bachelors are unmarried") and synthetic (true by fact). Quine argues the notion of analyticity cannot be non-circularly defined.
- To explain "analytic" you appeal to synonymy ("bachelor" = "unmarried man"); to explain synonymy you appeal to definition / interchangeability / necessity — but each of these presupposes analyticity again. The circle never breaks. So "analytic" is not a clear, principled category.
- Dogma 2 — reductionism (verificationism).
- The dogma that each meaningful statement is equivalent to some construction upon terms referring to immediate experience — i.e. every sentence has its own private range of confirming experiences. Quine rejects this.
- Positive doctrine — Confirmation Holism ("web of belief"):

MEMORY HOOK

CLAIM → REASON → CONSEQUENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED REPLY.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Quine attacks two unquestioned dogmas of logical empiricism:
2. Dogma 1 — the analytic/synthetic distinction.
3. Empiricists split truths into analytic (true by meaning alone, e.g. "all bachelors are unmarried") and synthetic (true by fact). Quine argues the notion of analyticity cannot be non-circularly defined.
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MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

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HIGH

1. QUINE — CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM ("Two Dogmas") — Part 2

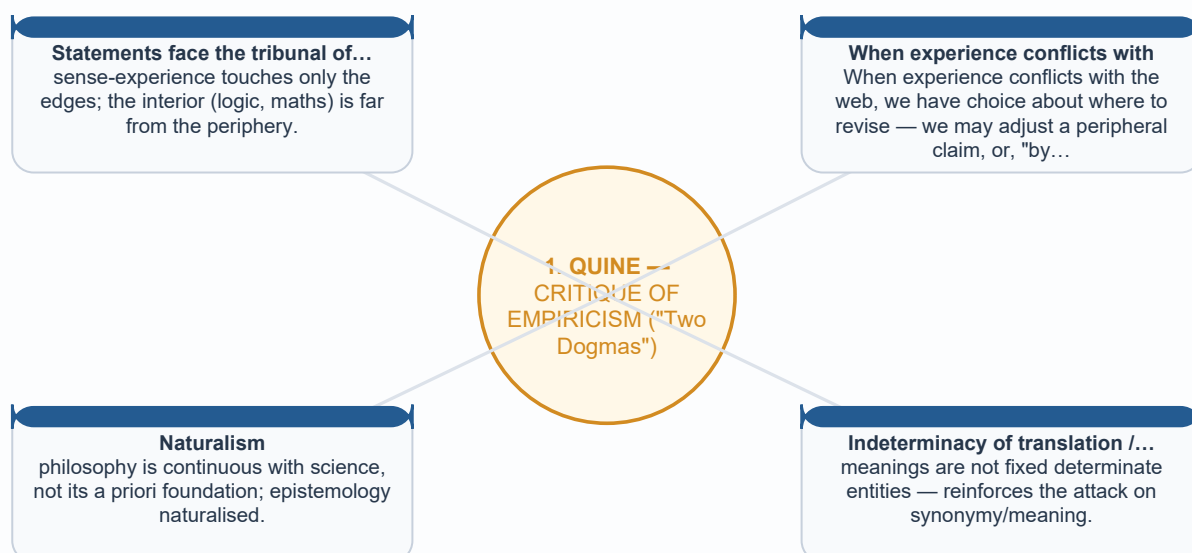
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Statements face the tribunal of experience not individually but only as a corporate body. Our knowledge is a web/field of force: sense-experience touches only the edges; the interior (logic, maths) is far from the periphery.

Continuation: preserve the full semantic chain before moving to criticism.

1. QUINE — CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM ("TWO DOGMAS") — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE

**STATIC THEORY**

- Statements face the tribunal of experience not individually but only as a corporate body. Our knowledge is a web/field of force: sense-experience touches only the edges; the interior (logic, maths) is far from the periphery.
- When experience conflicts with the web, we have choice about where to revise — we may adjust a peripheral claim, or, "by pleading hallucination" or even revising a law of logic, save any statement "come what may". No statement is immune; none is guaranteed a priori. → the a priori/a posteriori and analytic/synthetic lines blur.
- Naturalism: philosophy is continuous with science, not its a priori foundation; epistemology naturalised.
- Indeterminacy of translation / "gavagai": meanings are not fixed determinate entities — reinforces the attack on synonymy/meaning.
- Net effect: empiricism is not refuted from outside but reformed from within — Quine is a more consistent empiricist who abandons its two myths. This dissolves the positivists' sharp meaning-criterion (see 'Logical-Positivism.md').

MEMORY HOOK

Quine removes TWO dogmas; Strawson restores TWO basics: material bodies and persons.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Statements face the tribunal of experience not individually but only as a corporate body. Our knowledge is a web/field of force: sense-experience touches only the edges; the interior (logic, maths) is far from the...
2. When experience conflicts with the web, we have choice about where to revise — we may adjust a peripheral claim, or, "by pleading hallucination" or even revising a law of logic, save any statement "come what may". No...
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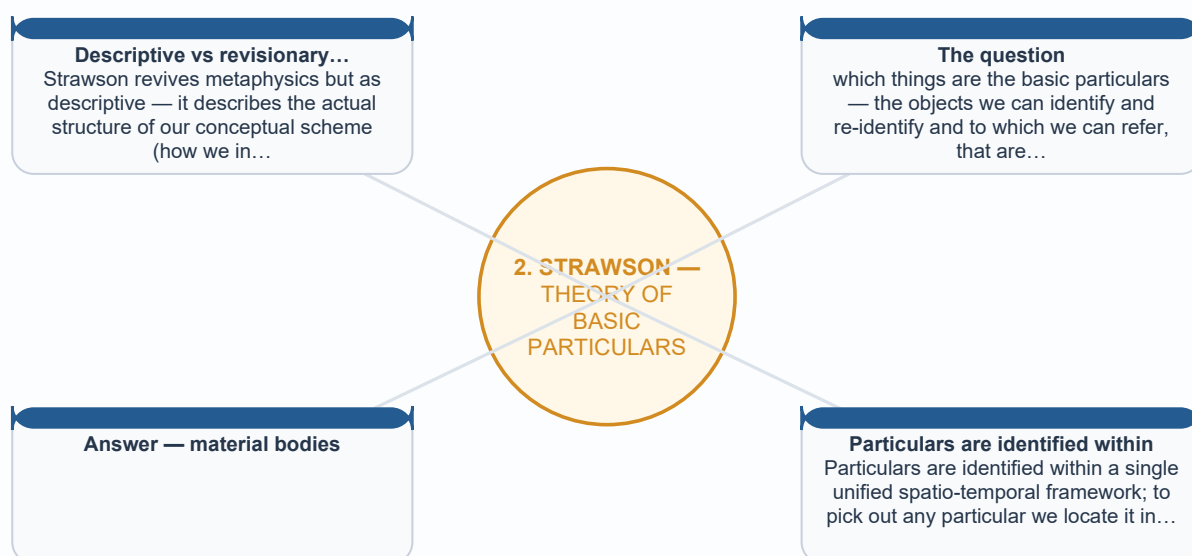
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HIGH**2. STRAWSON — THEORY OF BASIC PARTICULARS**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Descriptive vs revisionary metaphysics: Strawson revives metaphysics but as descriptive — it describes the actual structure of our conceptual scheme (how we in fact think about the world) rather than revising it (Descartes, Leibniz = revisionary).

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2. STRAWSON — THEORY OF BASIC PARTICULARS — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE

STATIC THEORY

- Descriptive vs revisionary metaphysics: Strawson revives metaphysics but as descriptive — it describes the actual structure of our conceptual scheme (how we in fact think about the world) rather than revising it (Descartes, Leibniz = revisionary).
- The question: which things are the basic particulars — the objects we can identify and re-identify and to which we can refer, that are ontologically fundamental in our scheme?
- Answer — material bodies:
- Particulars are identified within a single unified spatio-temporal framework; to pick out any particular we locate it in the one space-time system.
- Material bodies (and persons) are basic because they are the re-identifiable three-dimensional occupants of space that make the whole framework of identification possible.
- Other particulars (private experiences, sounds, processes, theoretical entities) are identifiable only by reference to material bodies — hence dependent, not basic. (A purely auditory "No-Space world" thought-experiment shows re-identification would collapse without bodies.)
- Upshot: a body-centred ontology; the material world is presupposed by our very ability to refer — an answer to scepticism about the external world different from proof (à la Moore) — it is a precondition of thought.

MEMORY HOOK

Quine removes TWO dogmas; Strawson restores TWO basics: material bodies and persons.

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HIGH

3. STRAWSON — THEORY OF PERSONS

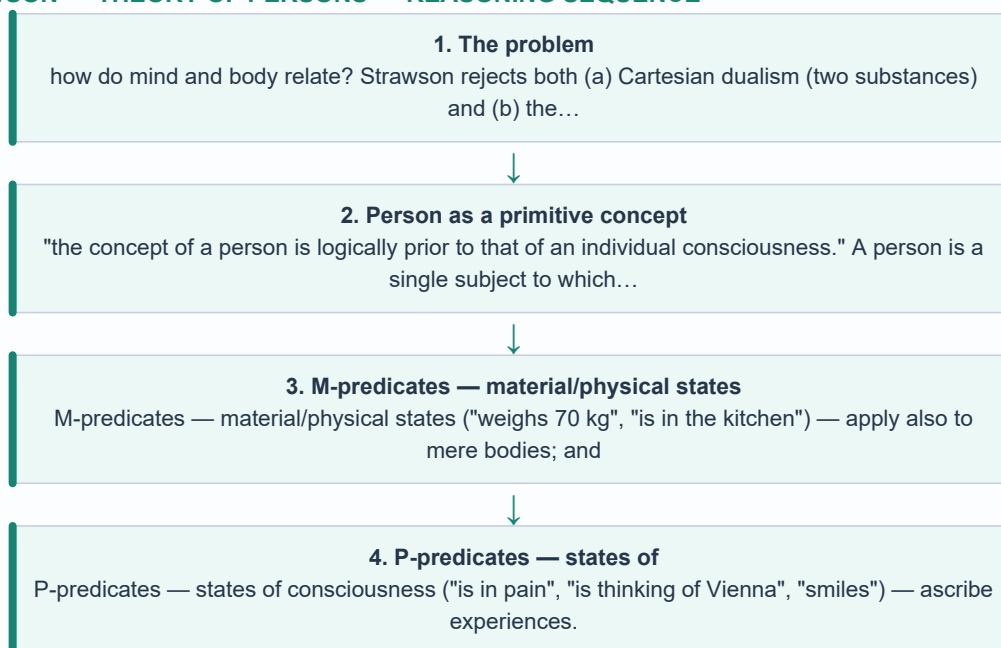
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The problem: how do mind and body relate? Strawson rejects both (a) Cartesian dualism (two substances) and (b) the "no-ownership"/no-subject theory (that experiences belong to no one).

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3. STRAWSON — THEORY OF PERSONS — REASONING SEQUENCE



STATIC THEORY

- The problem: how do mind and body relate? Strawson rejects both (a) Cartesian dualism (two substances) and (b) the "no-ownership"/no-subject theory (that experiences belong to no one).
- Person as a primitive concept: "the concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness." A person is a single subject to which we ascribe both:
- M-predicates — material/physical states ("weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen") — apply also to mere bodies; and
- P-predicates — states of consciousness ("is in pain", "is thinking of Vienna", "smiles") — ascribe experiences.
- Key argument (self-ascription requires other-ascription): I can ascribe experiences to myself only if I can, in principle, ascribe them to others — and I identify others as persons (embodied), by observing their behaviour. So P-predicates must be ascribable on the basis of observation (to others) yet not on that basis (to myself). This dual applicability is possible only if the subject is a person — a single entity of a special, unanalysable type, neither pure mind nor mere body.
- Result: the person is primitive/unanalysable — you cannot build it out of a body + a soul (dualism's error) or dissolve the owner (no-ownership's error). Dissolves the mind-body problem by refusing its dualist premise.

MEMORY HOOK

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MAINS ANGLE

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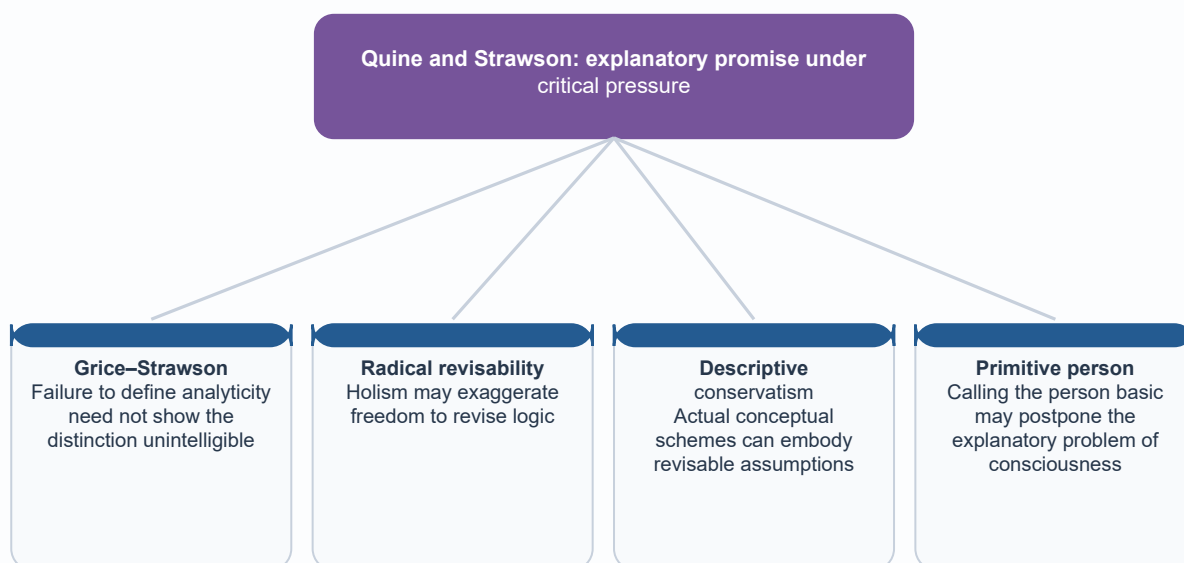
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HIGH**Criticisms, Replies, Comparisons and Verified Statement Bank**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A high-scoring critical answer distinguishes an external rejection from an immanent objection and gives the strongest available reply before judging the doctrine.

Statement bank retained only where the verified local topic file marks the wording as canonical; all other formulations are treated as paraphrase.

CLAIM–OBJECTION–REPLY ARCHITECTURE

KEY DATA

Axis	Quine	Strawson	Logical Positivism	Descartes
Analytic/synthetic	rejects (untenable)	(retains, cautiously)	central	—
Meaning	holistic, indeterminate	ordinary conceptual scheme	verification	clear & distinct ideas
Metaphysics	naturalised away	descriptive metaphysics revived	meaningless	revisionary
Mind–body	naturalist	person = primitive (P + M predicates)	—	two substances (dualism)
Method	science-continuous	connective analysis of concepts	logical analysis	doubt

STATIC THEORY

- **Critical pressure:** Grice–Strawson — Failure to define analyticity need not show the distinction unintelligible
- **Critical pressure:** Radical revisability — Holism may exaggerate freedom to revise logic
- **Critical pressure:** Descriptive conservatism — Actual conceptual schemes can embody revisable assumptions
- **Critical pressure:** Primitive person — Calling the person basic may postpone the explanatory problem of consciousness

MEMORY HOOK

C-O-R-J: CLAIM → strongest OBJECTION → plausible REPLY → reasoned JUDGEMENT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. "Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body." — Quine.
2. "Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system." — Quine.
3. "The concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness." — Strawson.
4. Descriptive metaphysics = "content to describe the actual structure of our thought about the world."

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Criticism means listing hostile names.

CORRECT: State the objection's premise, target and consequence.

WRONG: A quotation can replace exposition.

CORRECT: Unpack the statement's technical meaning and argumentative role.

WRONG: Comparison is two separate summaries.

CORRECT: Compare axis-by-axis around a shared problem.

COMPARATIVE ROUTES

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Analyticity	Logical positivism	Quine attacks a central distinction
Synthetic a priori	Kant	Holism blurs the a priori/a posteriori boundary
Substance	Aristotle to Hume	Basic particulars reinterpret the bearer question
Person	Descartes and Buddhism	Compare dualist subject, primitive person and no-self

MAINS ANGLE

Use the statement as a compressed argument: define its terms, reconstruct what follows, stage the strongest objection and give a qualified verdict.

STUDY LINK

Verified knowledge file: Quine-Strawson.md •
Direct local reading: Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 51–86; Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 801–803 (Quine) and 914–916 (Strawson); cross-checked with the local substance and a priori theme files.

HIGH**PYQs, Applied Drills and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Architecture**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The final layer converts doctrine into directive-sensitive answers. Keep exposition proportionate to marks, reserve space for criticism and end with a qualified philosophical judgement.

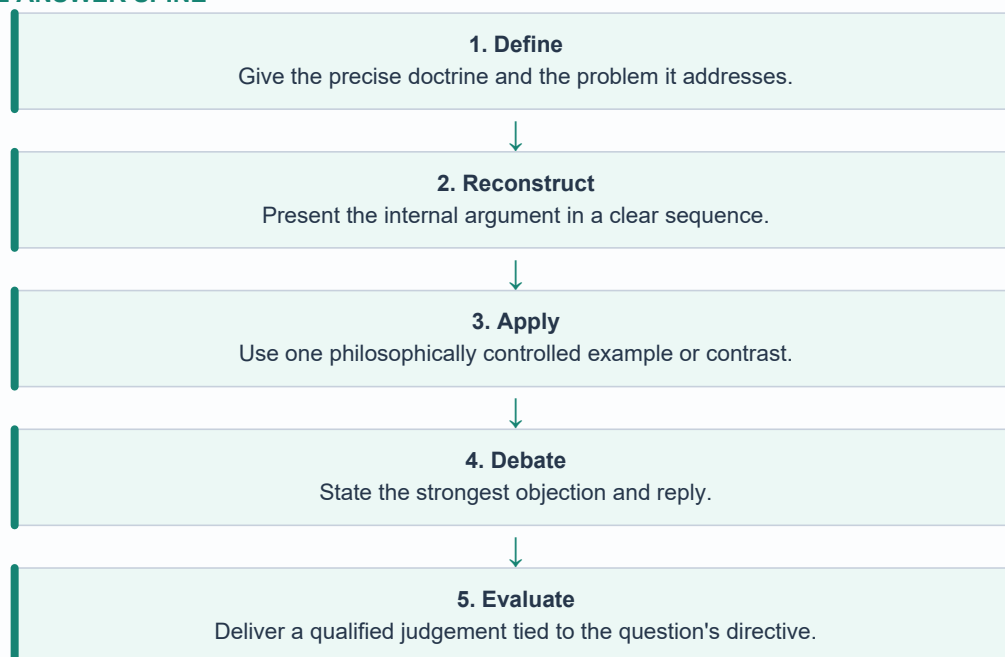
PYQs reproduced from the local UPSC Western Philosophy bank for 2022–2025; wording is shortened only in the table, not altered in doctrinal demand.

RECENT DIRECT PYQ YIELD

Bar length represents marks, not frequency.

KEY DATA

Year	Verified Demand	Marks
2025	Quine: adjustments within the total system	15
2024	Nature of the two dogmas	15
2023	Strawson: person as primitive and dualism	20

D-R-A-D-E ANSWER SPINE**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** 2-line context; define the key term; 3–4 linked doctrinal points; one precise objection; 2-line judgement.
- **15 marks:** establish the problem; reconstruct the argument with technical vocabulary; add comparison or example; objection–reply; balanced conclusion.
- **20 marks:** map every syllabus dimension in the question; develop the derivation; compare alternatives; stage two critical pressures; defend or qualify; conclude with an explicit criterion of success.
- [Critique] "Discuss Quine's critique of the two dogmas of empiricism."
- [Holism] "Explain Quine's confirmation holism and its bearing on the analytic/synthetic distinction."
- [Particulars] "What are basic particulars? Why are material bodies basic for Strawson?"
- [Persons] "Examine Strawson's concept of the person as a primitive."
- [Compare] "How do Quine and Strawson each challenge classical empiricism?"
- **7.1 — "Discuss Quine's critique of empiricism / the two dogmas." (recurring)**
 - Intro : Quine reforms empiricism from within by rejecting two dogmas.
 - B1 : dogma 1 — analytic/synthetic undefinable (synonymy circle).
 - B2 : dogma 2 — reductionism/verificationism false → confirmation HOLISM (web of belief);
 - no statement immune, none purely a priori.
 - Link : naturalism; dissolves positivist meaning-criterion & Kant's a priori.
 - Assess: powerful; but Grice–Strawson reply — the distinction is ordinarily intelligible.
 - Concl : a more consistent, holistic empiricism without its founding myths.

MEMORY HOOK

MARKS CONTROL DEPTH: 10 = compact argument; 15 = argument + debate; 20 = complete architecture + sustained evaluation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The directive determines emphasis: explain, examine, compare and evaluate are not interchangeable.
2. A 20-mark answer must show relations among subparts, not merely add more bullet points.
3. Use one stable example through exposition and criticism where possible.
4. Conclusions should identify what the doctrine successfully explains and what remains unresolved.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Memorise one essay for every wording.

CORRECT: Adapt the same doctrine map to the directive and marks.

WRONG: Criticism should occupy most of the answer.

CORRECT: Secure accurate exposition before proportionate evaluation.

WRONG: A conclusion merely repeats the introduction.

CORRECT: It must state a defended philosophical judgement.

MAINS ANGLE

For statement questions, treat the quotation as a claim needing reconstruction; for comparison, organise by axes; for 'does it solve' questions, state an explicit success criterion.

STUDY LINK

Official local PYQ bank:

[_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2022-2025.md](#)

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI